Theseus

By Barbara McBride-Smith

NOTE: Best if told with a Texas "twang"

Theseus is a Greek word that means "forgetful." OK, so it's not, but it ought to be.

When Theseus was born, his daddy picked him up, turned him around a few times, looked deep into his eyes, and said to the mama, "Hon, this boy's got a few cogs without a matching ratchet." Now, he could have said a lot of things that would have become self-fulfilling prophecies about Theseus. He could have said:

"This boy's elevator don't go all the way to the top."

"He don't have both oars in the water."

"He ain't the sharpest quill on the porcupine."

"His dipstick don't reach his oil."

Or . . . "He must have gotten into the gene pool when the lifeguard wasn't looking,"

4NG Fanatics

He could have said any of those things. But what he said was, "This boy's got a few cogs without a matching ratchet." And the daddy was right.

Then the daddy took a sword and a pair of shoes, buried them in a hole in the back yard, covered them up with a big ol' rock, and said to his wife. "Hon, when this boy gets big enough to move that rock, and smart enough to know what's under it, send him around to see me." And the daddy was outta there!

INTRODUCTION

In the original myth, Theseus, a hero of Greek legends, was known for his quick wits. His cleverness made him one of the great monster slayers of Greek mythology. But for Barbara McBride-Smith – Greek mythology is just a bit overwhelming, so she has re-written the myths, added her own special Texas trade-mark and just a bit of humor to make them more palatable. And even though in this version, Theseus may have some mismatched cogs . . . the basis of the myth remains the same . . . Theseus vs the Minotaur!

The mama did the best she could raising Theseus. But by the time he was a teenager, he was starting to get on his mama's nerves. That boy couldn't remember

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anything she told him. Besides that, when it came to following directions, he was slower than a herd of turtles stampeding through peanut butter. Every day the mama would say, "Son, do you remember that hole out there in the back yard?"

"Uh, sure, Mom."

"Well, go out there and see if you can move that rock off it."

"Sure, Mom."

But before he could get all the way out to that rock, he would trip over an anthill and lose track of where he was going. Or he'd get caught up in a game of "Gotcha" with his friends and forget all about what he was supposed to be doing.

You see, "Gotcha" was Theseus's favorite game, and he whiled away many an hour playing it. This is how it works: everybody, except the one who is It, goes out into the woods and hides up in the trees. The one who is It then walks under the trees looking for the ones who are hiding. Suddenly somebody up in a tree jumps down on the one who is It, knocking the one who is It to the

4NG Fanatics

ground, sometimes rendering the one who is It unconscious. The one doing the jumping then hollers, "Gotcha!"

Theseus loved being It. He was so good at being It, everybody let him be It all the time. He would go walking along under those trees and somebody would jump down on him. But Theseus always heard them before they landed on him. He could hear the leaves rustle. He could hear the air move. So before anybody could lay a hand on him, he would whirl around, knock 'em about a hundred yards, and holler, "Gotcha back!"

Theseus's mama would see him dragging back in the house a few hours after she'd sent him out, and she'd say, "Are you coming back in here without that rock?"

Theseus would wrinkle up his brow like he was working on a problem in quantum physics and say, "What rock?"

One day, the mama got fed up. She grabbed Theseus by the ear and dragged him out to the back

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yard. "That rock, son. Do you see that rock? Well, move it!"

Theseus didn't know how strong he was. He picked up that big ol' rock with one hand and tossed it aside.

"Now, what do you see down there in that hole?" asked his mama.

"Uh, a sword and a pair of shoes."

"Congratulations, Son. You pass with an A." The mama slapped a map into one of his hands and a sack lunch into the other. "Good luck with your daddy" she said. And the mama was outta there!

Theseus's daddy had taken up residence in a place called Athens, so that's where Theseus headed. The Athenian Road was a very dangerous road. It was infested with a bunch of ragtag, third-rate burglars and bandits. They hid in the bushes and trees alongside the road. When wayfarers went down that road, carrying suitcases, pushing baby buggies, those creeps would jump down on 'em, rob and terrorize 'em, and generally act like hoodlums. Well, when the terrible stories about

4NG Fanatics

the road made the front-page news, people were afraid to travel to Athens anymore. But what did Theseus know about current events? Diddly squat! But luckily, this situation was made to order for Theseus's unique talents. He went merrily down that road, and when those burglars and bandits jumped down on him, he heard the leaves rustle and the air move. He whirled around, knocked 'em about a hundred yards, and hollered, "Gotcha back!" Those perverts were never seen again, and the Athenian Road became a shining example of early urban renewal.

Well, when word got out in Athens about this big hero who was coming to town, folks turned out to cheer his arrival. Meanwhile, Theseus's daddy, Aegeus, who was now king of Athens and enjoying the company of a girlfriend named Medea, got very worried. He had no idea that the road hero was his very own son. Medea, who did not have a stellar reputation in family relations, convinced Aegeus that this hero might be elected the new king of Athens and that poor ol' Aegeus would be

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left crownless, powerless, and penniless. So she hatched a plot to poison the mysterious hero.

When Theseus got to town, Aegeus and Medea greeted him at the city gates and handed him a cup of wine. As Theseus tipped the beverage to his lips, Aegeus recognized the sharp sword and the dusty shoes he had buried so long ago. He realized that this hero was none other than his abandoned son. Aegeus knocked the cup of poison from the boy's lips and embraced him. "My son, at last I've found you!"

It so happened that these were tough times in Athens. A few years back, Athens had gotten into a scuffle with the island of Crete. The Athenians had lost. So now every nine years, as payment to the King of Crete, Athens was required to send seven young men and seven young women to Crete, where they were fed to a monstrous Minotaur. When Theseus heard of this atrocity, he said, "Hey! I've got a swell idea! I'm a big-time hero. How about if I go along on the boat this time and just kill that . . . uh . . . that . . . Whaddya call that thing? Oh, year, Minotaur! Yep, I'll just kill that

4NG Fanatics

Minotaur. No problem. Well, so long. See you later . . . uh . . . see you later . . . Whaddya call yourself? Dad! Yep, see you later, Dad!"

The next day, Theseus joined the thirteen other adolescents bound for Crete. The shop was launched under black sails, befitting the occasion. But Theseus promised Aegeus that if the mission was successful, they would return under white sails. Aegeus could look out over the water and know before the ship ever reached shore whether or not his son was alive.

When the ship reached Crete, the young Athenians went ashore, led by Theseus. The first person who greeted them was a beautiful island girl who fell in love with Theseus the moment she laid eyes on him. She looked him up, and she looked him down, and she liked what she saw. Then she looked deep into his eyes, and she said to herself, "Mmm, this boy's got a few cogs without a matching ratchet." Theseus was her best hope, so the girl tried not to think about the consequences.

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Now this girl was no run-of-the-mill citizen of Crete. She was Ariadne, daughter of King Minos and half-sister to the Minotaur. She walked along next to Theseus and explained to him about the labyrinth where her daddy kept the Minotaur. She told him she was certain that he was strong enough to destroy the Minotaur. But, she said, he could never find his way out of that labyrinth without a little help from her. She'd be happy to provide some assistance, explained Ariadne, if he would take her with him as his wife when he left Crete.

"Sure, Mom . . . uh, sure, Dad . . . uh, sure, Ari-something. Sure, take you with me . . . whatever."

When they reached the entrance to the labyrinth, Ariadne handed Theseus a golden ball of string. She told him to let that string unwind behind him as he made his way through the maze of passages. Once he killed the Minotaur, all he had to do was follow the string back to her. She said she'd be waiting with her wedding dress and her running shoes.

4NG Fanatics

Theseus led his not-so-merry band of thirteen through the door of the labyrinth, unwinding the golden string as he went. The passageway was dark and dank and narrow, twisting and turning back on itself like a snake. When they reached the innermost part of the maze, Theseus felt the movement of air above him. The bull-headed monster jumped from his hiding place on the wall overhead, snorting and spewing phlegm on the intruders. But Theseus, anticipating the attack, stepped aside and whirled around, and before the Minotaur could lay a hoof on anybody, Theseus knocked him about a hundred yards. "Gotcha back!" he yelled. The Minotaur lay dead, deader than a doornail.

Theseus sat down on the lifeless body of the monster and pouted. "Shucks. Now how in the name of Sam Hill are we supposed to get out of this lousy place?"

His friends looked deep into his eyes and said to themselves, "This boy's got a few cogs without a matching ratchet." They could have said a lot of things, but what they did was yell real loud, "The string, stupid, the string!"

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Theseus looked down at the ball of string still in his hand. "Sure. Right. I knew that. I was just checking. Come on. Follow me. I'm getting you people outta here!"

They picked up Ariadne at the door, ran for the harbor, and sailed away from the island of Crete at full speed. That night they stopped to rest on the island of Naxos. Ariadne unpacked her wedding frock, and she and Theseus were married by the local justice of the peace. It was the shortest honeymoon in history. Before the crack of dawn, Theseus loaded the crew and the bags back onto the ship and set sail for Athens. Not far out of the harbor, one of his shipmates looked back and yelled, "Ariadne! Theseus, you forgot Ariadne!" Sure enough, there she stood, knee deep in the ocean, still in her nightgown, frantically waving her arms.

"Who?" said Theseus. "Ari-who? Oh, yeah, her. Nice girl. Well, home to Athens. Full-speed ahead!" Would you believe it? He forgot about her. Went off and left her and forgot all about her. And that wasn't even the worst thing that happened that day.

4NG Fanatics

As the ship approached Athens, Aegeus was standing on a high, rocky cliff gazing out over the horizon. When he saw the vessel, he began to weep, and he threw himself to his death on the rocks below. You want to guess what color the sails were? That's right – black. Theseus forgot to change them!

That's how the rest of Theseus's life went. One faux pas after another. He messed up so many times, nobody bothered to keep track for posterity anymore.

Once he went down to the underworld, thinking he could rescue a beautiful woman named Persephone. Hades caught him, of course, and punished him by making him sit in the Chair of Forgetfulness. What a hoot! Theseus felt right at home. He sat there looking mellow, forgetting who he was and what he was supposed to be doing. But, you see, that Chair of Forgetfulness was a fiendish device. It not only took away your memory, but it also sealed itself to your rear end like Super Glue. Theseus would still be there if it hadn't been for his pal Hercules who followed him down there, grabbed hold of him, and ripped him out of that chair,

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leaving part of Theseus still attached. That's why, by the way, to this very day Theseus's descendants are known as "half-ass people."

How that boy Theseus ever got to be a hero to the Greeks is a complete mystery to me. On the one hand, he screwed up just about everything he touched. On the other hand, he did clean up the Athenian Road, and he did rid the world of the Minotaur, and he did bring those thirteen young people home safe to Athens. So I guess you could say he did the best he could for a boy who had a few cogs without a matching ratchet.

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